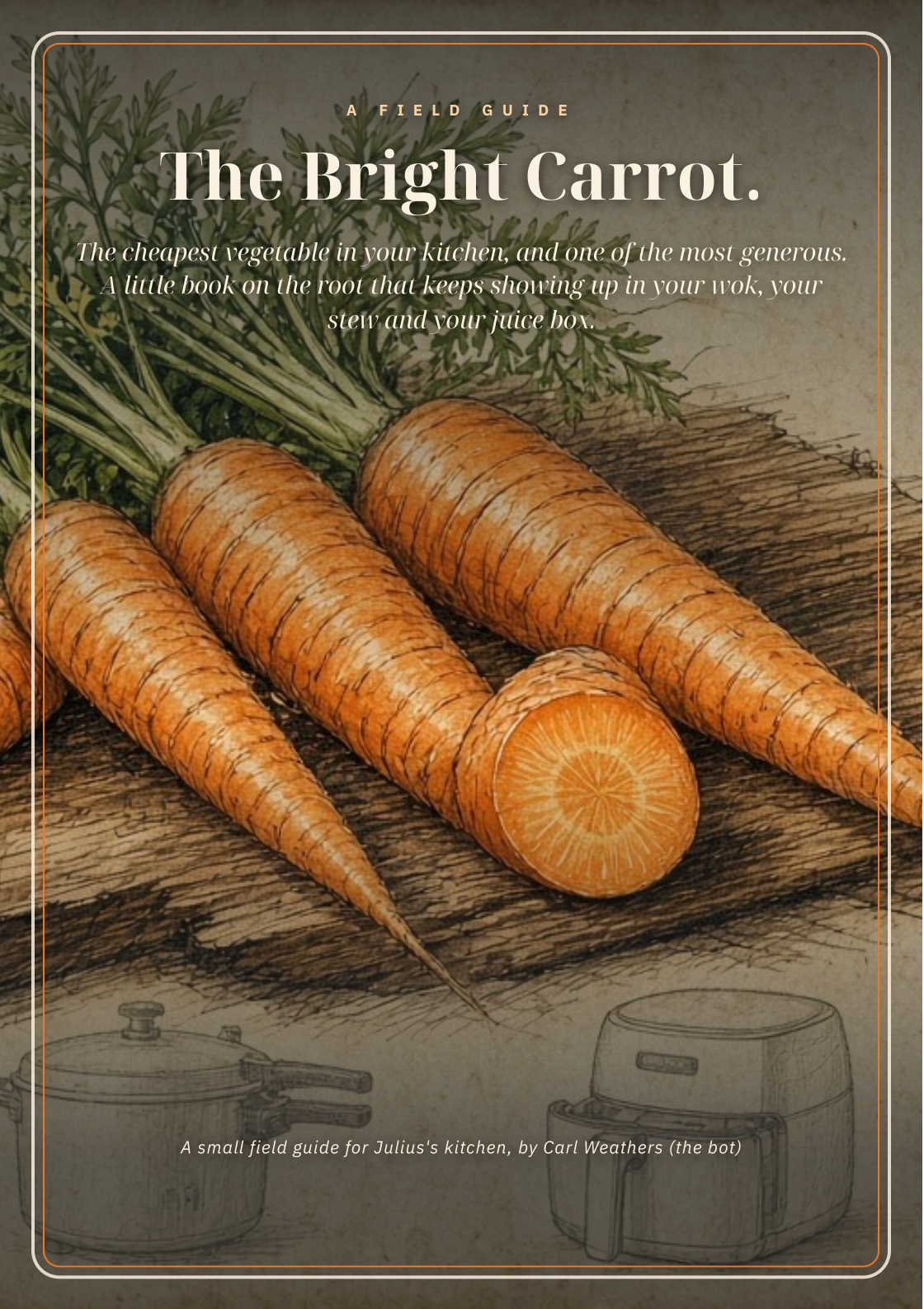
A FIELD GUIDE

The Bright Carrot.

The cheapest vegetable in your kitchen, and one of the most generous. A little book on the root that keeps showing up in your wok, your stew and your juice box.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

You already know this one. It was in Tuesday's wok with the chicken and broccoli, and it's half of that red tomato-and-carrot juice you drink. A whole kilo costs you about sixteen baht, not much more than one bottle of Coke. It keeps for weeks without complaining, it goes sweet in the air fryer, soft in the stew and crisp in a pickle, and it brings more vitamin A per baht than almost anything you can buy. Nothing fancy here. Just a steady, honest root that makes everything around it better. Let's get a stew going, baby.



SECTION I · MEET THE CARROT

The Family

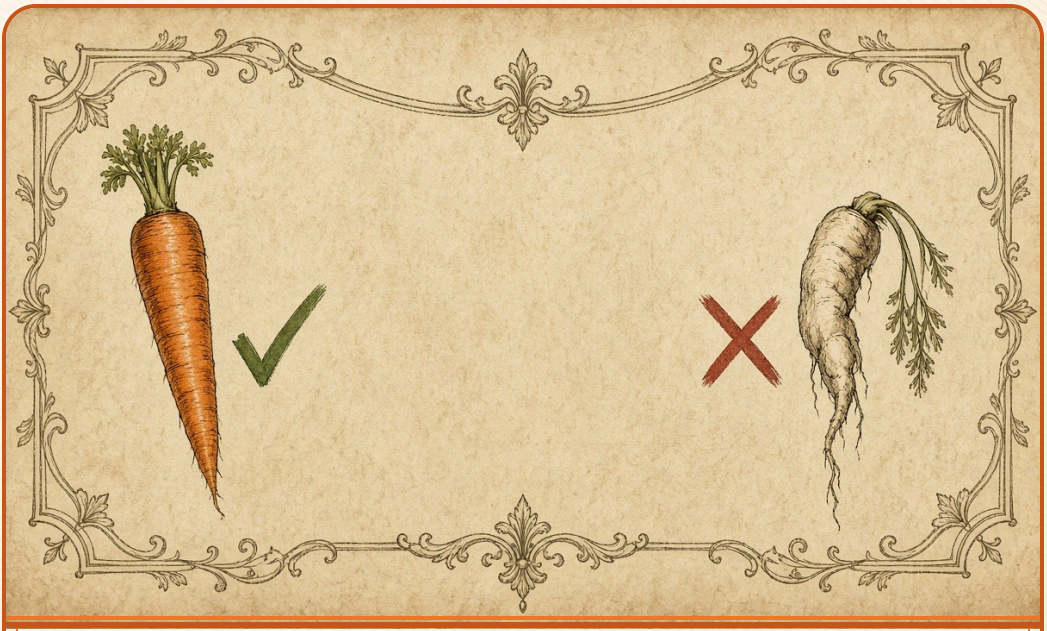
- **Big orange carrots:** the everyday kind, sold loose or in kilo bags. Sweet, crunchy and sturdy. This is what you buy from Freshket.
- **Baby carrots:** either a small young variety picked early, or big carrots cut down and polished into little bullets. Tender and pricey.
- **Shredded carrots:** already grated, sold in bags. Handy for a fast stir-fry or salad, but they dry out within days.
- **The old colors:** purple, yellow, white and red carrots. Carrots were purple and yellow long before they were orange, and you'll still see them at specialty shops.
- **Its cousins (same plant family):** parsnip, celery, parsley, coriander, dill and fennel. That's why carrot and coriander taste so good together.



Names at the Thai Market

- **แครอท** (khae-rot): carrot. This is the word on almost every label.
- **หัวผักกาดแดง** (hua phak kat daeng): "red radish root," an older Thai name for the carrot you'll still hear from older vendors.
- **เบบี้แครอท** (baby khae-rot): baby carrots.
- **แครอทขูด** (khae-rot khut): grated or shredded carrot.
- **น้ำแครอท** (nam khae-rot): carrot juice.
- **ไข่ผัดแครอท** (khai phat khae-rot): carrot stir-fried with egg, a classic home dish.

(Thai carrots mostly come from the cool northern highlands, and many are imported from China in the hot months. Labels vary from shop to shop, so trust your eyes.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AT THE MARKET

Reading the Signs

- It should be **firm and snap cleanly**. Bendy, rubbery carrots are old and dried out.
- Look for **deep, even orange** color. Deeper orange means more carotene.
- Smooth skin is best. A few fine root hairs are fine; lots of hairy roots mean it's been sitting.
- **Green shoulders** (where the top was in the sun) taste a little bitter. Trim them off.
- If the greens are still on, they should be bright and fresh, not slimy.
- No soft spots, cracks that are dark or wet, or white mold at the tip.
- Medium carrots are usually sweeter and less woody than giant ones.



SECTION III · STORAGE

Keeping It Crisp

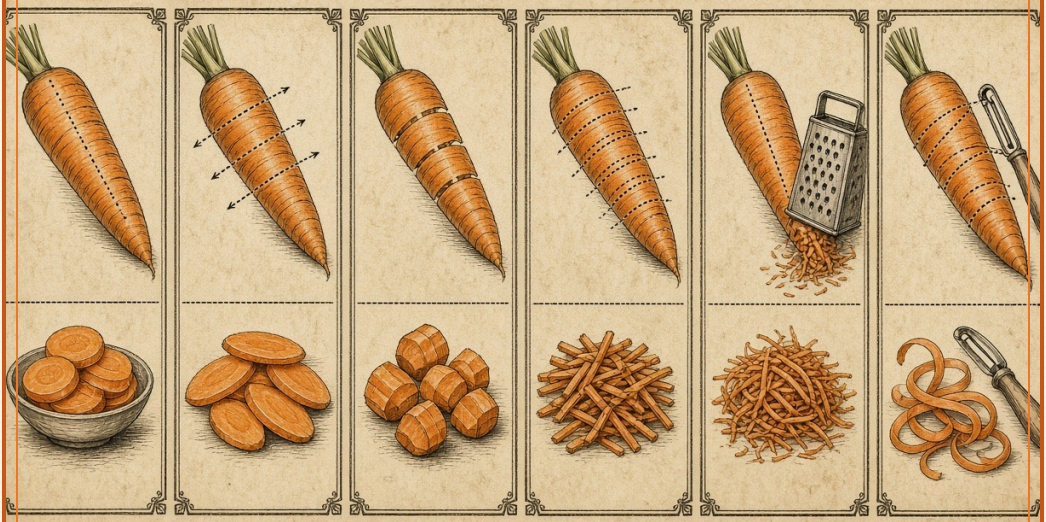
1. **Cut the green tops off right away**, leaving a little stub. The leaves keep pulling water out of the root.
2. Keep carrots **unwashed and dry**, in a bag in the crisper drawer. They last about **3 to 4 weeks** *(estimate, common kitchen practice)*.
3. Keep them away from apples, bananas and mangoes. The gas those fruits give off can turn carrots bitter.
4. **Cut sticks** stay crisp in a jar of water in the fridge for about **4 to 5 days**. Change the water every day or two *(estimate)*.
5. **Freezing:** blanch coins or sticks in boiling water for **2 to 3 minutes**, plunge into ice water, dry, and freeze flat in a bag. They keep for about **10 to 12 months** *(estimate)* and go straight into stews and soups from frozen.
6. Shredded carrots from a bag last only a few days. Use them first.
7. Once it's slimy, moldy or smells sour, throw it out.



SECTION IV · PREP AND CUTS

To Peel or Not

You don't have to peel a carrot. A hard scrub under the tap with a brush or a rough cloth is enough, and the skin is perfectly good to eat. Peel when the skin is old, hairy or dark, or when you want a clean, bright orange for a soup or a pickle. Use a peeler, not a knife, and always trim the top and the very tip.



Six Cuts

- **Coins:** rounds about 5 mm thick. For soups, steaming and the sous vide bag.
- **Diagonal slices:** the same, but angled. More surface, so they cook faster and catch more sauce. The classic wok cut.
- **Roll cut:** cut on the diagonal, roll the carrot a quarter turn, cut again. Chunky, even pieces for stews and the air fryer.
- **Matchsticks (julienne):** thin diagonal slices, stacked and cut into fine sticks. For stir-fries, pickles and salads.
- **Grated:** on the big holes of a box grater. For carrot-egg stir-fry, fritters and salad.
- **Ribbons:** run a peeler down the length of the carrot. For quick pickles and a pretty salad.

Rule: Keep the pieces the same size so they cook at the same speed. Big chunks for long cooking, thin cuts for fast heat.



SECTION V · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time and temperature
Wok, stir-fry	Diagonal slices or matchsticks	High heat, 2–4 min, splash of water to steam them through
Wok, carrot-egg stir-fry	Grated	Medium-high, 2–3 min until soft, then the egg
Instant Pot, steamed carrots	Coins or sticks, on the trivet	High pressure 2–3 min, quick release *(estimate, common practice)*
Instant Pot, chicken stew	Big roll-cut chunks	High pressure 8–10 min with boneless thighs, natural release 10 min
Instant Pot, carrot-ginger soup	Coins	High pressure 5 min, then blend *(estimate)*
Air fryer, roasted carrots	Roll-cut or sticks about 2 cm thick, oiled	390°F / 200°C for 15–20 min, shake halfway
Air fryer, carrot fries	Batons about 1 cm, oiled, dried well	380°F / 190°C for 14–18 min, shake twice *(estimate, watch closely)*
Sous vide, butter carrots	Coins or baby carrots, in the bag	183°F / 84°C for 45–60 min *(estimate, common practice)*



Method Notes

- **Wok:** Carrots are harder than most vegetables, so they go in **first**, before the bok choy or broccoli. Thin cuts and a splash of water get them tender without burning the outside.
- **Instant Pot:** Carrots alone turn to mush fast under pressure. In a stew with meat, cut them **big** so they come out tender, not baby food.
- **Air fryer:** Dry them well and toss in a little oil. Don't crowd the basket, or they steam instead of browning. The browned edges are where the sweetness lives.
- **Sous vide:** Vegetables need a hotter bath than meat. At 183°F / 84°C the cell walls soften, while the sweetness and color stay sealed in the bag. Finish with a quick toss in a hot pan if you like.
- **Heat helps here.** Cooking softens the carrot's tough cell walls, which lets your body get at more of the beta-carotene. A little fat in the dish helps too.



SECTION VI · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts. Season to taste.

Carrot and Egg Stir-Fry (ไข่ผัดแครอท)

Grate two carrots. Heat a little oil in the wok and fry some chopped garlic for a few seconds. Add the carrot and stir-fry for 2–3 minutes until it softens and turns deep orange. Push it to the side, crack in two or three eggs, let them set for a moment, then fold everything together. Season with fish sauce or a splash of soy sauce and plenty of white pepper. Finish with scallion. Five minutes, about twenty baht with the eggs, and it's on rice.



Ginger Chicken, Carrot and Potato Stew (Instant Pot)

Sauté onion, garlic and a few smashed ginger coins in the pot. Add boneless chicken thighs, **big roll-cut carrots**, potato chunks, a splash of fish sauce, and bone broth or water to just cover. High pressure for **8–10 minutes**, then natural release for 10. Season, stir in a handful of bok choy at the end to wilt, and spoon over rice. It's a cousin of your pepper jack stew, lighter and cheaper, and it freezes well in single portions.



Honey-Ginger Air-Fried Carrots

Roll-cut carrots into chunks about 2 cm thick. Toss with oil, salt, a little honey and grated ginger. Air fry at **390°F / 200°C for 15–20 minutes**, shaking halfway, until the edges are browned and caramelized. Squeeze lime over the top and serve with a spoon of Greek yogurt mixed with garlic and salt. A good side for salmon or chicken thighs.



Silky Carrot-Ginger Soup

Sauté onion and a thumb of ginger in butter in the Instant Pot. Add a big pile of carrot coins and enough broth to cover. High pressure for **5 minutes** *(estimate)*, quick release, then blend until smooth. Season with salt and white pepper, and finish with a swirl of yogurt. It's lovely warm after a cold morning swim, and it keeps in the fridge for about 4 days *(estimate)*.



Butter Carrots, Sous Vide

Seal carrot coins or baby carrots in a bag with a knob of butter, a pinch of salt and a little honey. Cook at **183°F / 84°C for 45–60 minutes** *(estimate, common practice)*. Pour into a hot pan for a minute to glaze. They come out tender all the way through and sweeter than any boiled carrot you've had.



Quick Pickled Carrot Ribbons

Peel carrots into long ribbons (add some daikon if you have it). Warm rice vinegar with a little sugar and salt until dissolved, cool it, and pour it over the ribbons in a jar. Ready in 30 minutes, better the next day, and good in the fridge for about 1 to 2 weeks *(estimate)*. A sharp, crunchy bite next to salmon, grilled pork, rice bowls or a sandwich.



SECTION VII · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Proteins:** chicken thighs, beef and beef bones, pork, salmon, eggs, shrimp.
- **Vegetables:** potatoes, onion, broccoli, bok choy, cabbage, celery, green beans, daikon, pumpkin.
- **Aromatics and herbs:** ginger (its best friend), garlic, coriander, scallion, dill, cumin, black and white pepper.
- **Sauces and sweet things:** butter, honey, lime, orange, rice vinegar, fish sauce, soy sauce, oyster sauce, miso, Greek yogurt.
- **Beans:** carrots in a pot of black or kidney beans, or carrot matchsticks tossed with edamame and sesame oil.



SECTION VIII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Raw

Nutrient	Per 100g	Per 80g (one medium-large carrot)
Energy	41 kcal	33 kcal
Carbohydrates	9.6 g	7.7 g
of which sugars	4.7 g	3.8 g
Fiber	2.8 g (~10% DV)	2.2 g
Protein	0.9 g	0.7 g
Fat	0.2 g	0.2 g
Vitamin A (RAE)	835 µg (~93% DV)	668 µg (~74% DV)
Beta-carotene	8,280 µg	6,624 µg
Vitamin K	13.2 µg (~11% DV)	10.6 µg
Potassium	320 mg (~7% DV)	256 mg
Vitamin C	5.9 mg (~7% DV)	4.7 mg
Vitamin B6	0.14 mg (~8% DV)	0.11 mg

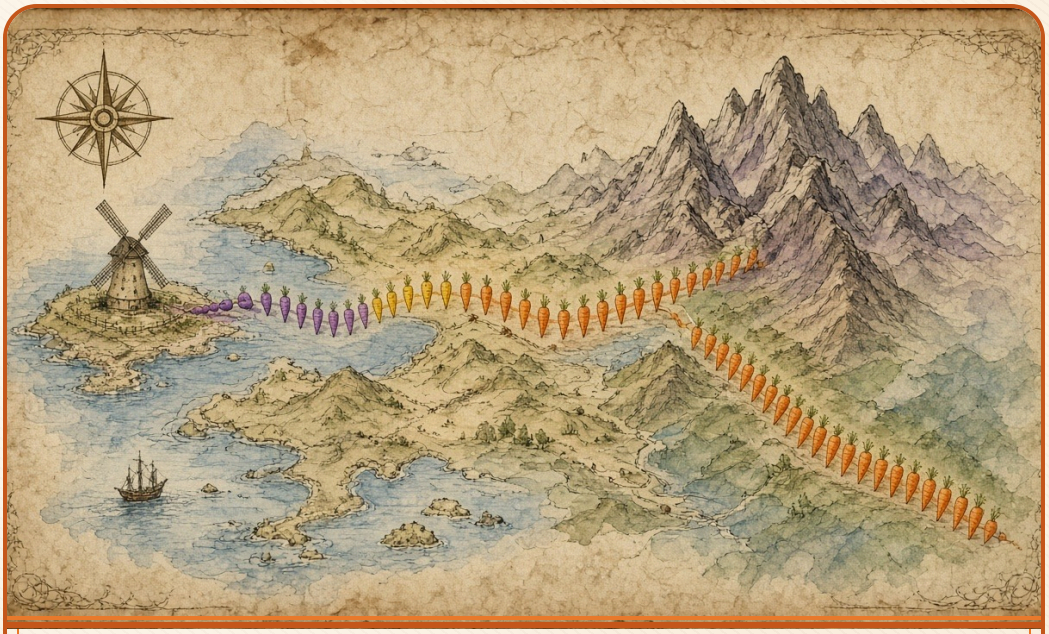
The sugar in a carrot is mostly sucrose, wrapped up in fiber and water, so it lands gently. One carrot covers most of a day's vitamin A, for about one baht.

Source: USDA FoodData Central, "Carrots, raw" (FDC 170393).



The Honest Note

Well established: carrots are one of the richest everyday sources of beta-carotene, which your body turns into vitamin A as it needs it. Vitamin A keeps your eyes working in low light, your skin healthy and your immune system running. Your body only converts what it needs, so you can't overdose on vitamin A from carrots. Eat a mountain of them and your palms may turn a little orange, which is harmless and fades. **The famous myth:** carrots won't give you super night vision. That story was spread in Britain during the Second World War to hide the fact that their pilots had radar. Carrots fix night blindness caused by a vitamin A shortage, but they don't sharpen normal eyes. **Promising but not proven:** people who eat lots of carotene-rich vegetables tend to have lower rates of heart disease and some cancers, but those studies watch people rather than test carrots, so the vegetables may be getting credit for a healthy life in general. **An important difference:** beta-carotene **pills** are not the same as carrots. In big trials, high-dose beta-carotene supplements raised lung cancer risk in smokers. Food is fine; the pills are a different story. **For absorption:** eat them with a little fat and cook them sometimes. It's the habit that counts, baby, not any single carrot.



SECTION IX · AN OLD NOTE

The Root That Changed Color

The first carrots people grew, more than a thousand years ago in the mountains of Persia and Central Asia, were purple and yellow, thin and a little bitter. They traveled west with traders into the Mediterranean and east along the old roads into China, and from China they reached the markets of Southeast Asia. The sweet orange carrot we know came later, bred by farmers in the Netherlands around the 1600s. People like to say it was made orange to honor the Dutch royal House of Orange, but that's probably just a good story. In Thai kitchens it slipped in quietly and stayed, grown on cool northern mountain farms that once grew opium and now grow vegetables. It's a humble root that ended up on every table in the world by being cheap, sweet, and easy to love.



SECTION X · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

All prices below are your own receipts from Freshket and Paleo Robbie. No web prices were checked for this chapter, and prices change.

Date	Item	Pack	Paid	Per kg	Per 100g
Nov 24, 2025	Whole carrots (Freshket)	1 kg	฿25	~฿26	~฿2.6
Dec 26, 2025	Whole carrots (Freshket)	1 kg	฿22	~฿22	~฿2.2
Dec 26, 2025	Shredded carrots (Freshket)	500 g	฿25	฿50	฿5.0
May 13, 2026	Whole carrots (Freshket)	1 kg	฿20	~฿20	~฿2.0
Aug 12, 2026	Whole carrots (Freshket)	1 kg	฿15	฿15	฿1.5
Sep 13, 2026	Whole carrots (Freshket)	1 kg	฿16	฿16	฿1.6
Mar 19, 2026	Organic carrots (Paleo Robbie)	500 g	฿59	฿118	฿11.8
Oct 13, 2025	Organic French baby carrots (Paleo Robbie)	300 g	฿159	฿530	฿53

Rule of thumb: Whole carrots from Freshket have cost you ฿15–26 per kg, about **฿1.5 to ฿2.6 per 100g**. Shredded costs two to three times that, organic about seven times, and baby carrots more than thirty times. Buy the plain kilo bag and grate them yourself.

What a dinner costs: The ginger chicken, carrot and potato stew, using about 400g boneless chicken thigh, 300g carrots, 300g potatoes, 100g onion, 20g ginger and 15g garlic, comes to about **฿87** at your prices, or about **฿29 a bowl** for three. The carrots are under ฿5 of that. Rice, fish sauce, oil, bok choy and broth aren't priced in this total.



Closing

Scrub it, cut it even, and put it in the pan first. One kilo, sixteen baht, a whole week of color on your plate. Go get a stew going, baby.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 170393 "Carrots, raw" (SR Legacy), fetched from the USDA FoodData Central API on Oct 18, 2026. Daily values are per 100g against FDA adult reference values (vitamin A 900 µg, vitamin K 120 µg, potassium 4,700 mg, vitamin C 90 mg, vitamin B6 1.7 mg, fiber 28 g).
- Safe internal temperature for chicken, 165°F / 74°C: USDA FSIS safe minimum temperature chart.
- Evidence summary: NIH Office of Dietary Supplements, "Vitamin A and Carotenoids" fact sheet, and the ATBC and CARET beta-carotene supplement trials. Summarized in plain words, not quoted. The wartime night-vision story is widely documented by historians.
- Instant Pot, sous vide, air fryer, storage and pickle times: common published practice, labeled as estimates.
- Prices: Julius's Freshket and Paleo Robbie invoices, in his food price book.